

United Overseas Bank (UOB)

First Take: PPop misses, gross NPL formation stays high; maintain UW

Our First Take: UOB declared full-year profits of S\$4.68bn, down 23% y/y. 4Q25 profit of S\$1.41bn was 2% above our estimate but 2% below the Street (Bloomberg consensus). PPop missed our forecasts by 7%, largely on seasonal weakness in flow-related treasury income. NIM came in better, likely helped by the full quarter effect of the Hibor rebound. Asset quality trends were unclear, and the data can be interpreted in many ways. Gross NPL formation was high at S\$599mn (vs. last 10Q avg of S\$414mn), but net NPL formation was negative on the back of upgrades, recoveries and write-offs. Looking at US and Greater China disclosures, it appears that formation was higher in GC with coverage at 60%, declining closer to 2Q25 levels, while US appears to have had a higher share of upgrades, recoveries and possibly write-offs in conjunction with higher GP allocation. Interestingly, for the bank, the GP coverage stayed above 1% of loans as most of the write-offs came from SPs (which were lower by S\$412mn q/q, 12bps of loans). Overall, while the bank was able to manage the delicate balance between GP cover of close to 1%, total coverage close to 100%, and deliver lower-than-anticipated credit costs, we do not see this quarter's results as an all-clear on AQ. The broader guidance (below) on NIM, fees, loan growth, costs and provisions appear broadly in line with our estimates. We are concerned that CIR for the bank may move up in 2026 after a year of cost consolidation in 2025. This, along with concerns on AQ, should limit upside on payout and stock price, in our view.

Other aspects that stood out include a small but important improvement in invested AUM to 42% (from 38% last year), and a 6% increase in HNW AUM. Going forward, NNM and invested AUM growth will require consistent investments from the bank, which may be a source of cost growth, among others. Further, CET1 improved to 14.9%, yet payout stayed at 50% of core (tax adj. for one-off 3Q provisions). This level of payout should sustain, which limits any shifts in cash dividend yield. UOB is leading Singapore banks on buybacks, with 23bps of CET1 used vs. ~10/14bps at DBS/OCBC. This should continue as well.

Overall, we expect negative revisions from the Street post 4Q results and 2026 guidance, unless the briefing suggests a meaningfully different conclusion. The stock is cheap vs. peers, but still above what we consider fair value for the next 12M, due to our concerns on AQ and costs at the bank. Hence, we stay with our UW rating and recommend investors switch to DBS and SGX within the sector. In case UOB is able to divest some of the assets ([link](#)) and improve payout, this may pose upside risk to our view.

UOB 2026 Targets

- Low single-digit loan growth
- Full-year NIM of 1.75% - 1.80%
- High single-digit fee growth

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Underweight

UOBH.SI, UOB SP

Price (23 Feb 26): S\$38.80

Price Target (Dec-26): S\$34.00



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- Low single-digit operating cost growth
- Total credit costs at 25-30 basis points

Key Positives

NIM improved 2bps q/q to 1.84%

Key Negatives/Question Marks

Gross NPL formation was S\$599mn vs. last 10Q avg of S\$414mn

Likely Changes to Consensus

We expect negative revisions from the Street

Expected Stock Reaction

A small negative

Conference Call Details

UOB is hosting a media briefing at 9am SGT and an analyst briefing at 10:15am SGT today.

Table 1: UOB: 4Q25 earnings review

P&L (\$mn)	4Q24	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25A	4Q25E	YoY	QoQ	JPM
Net Interest Income	2,451	2,409	2,336	2,265	2,346	2,276	-4%	4%	3%
Non-Interest Income	1,010	1,248	1,129	1,133	944	1,152	-7%	-17%	-18%
Fee Income	567	694	636	615	625	606	10%	2%	3%
Other Non-It	443	554	493	518	319	546	-28%	-38%	-42%
Operating Revenue	3,461	3,657	3,465	3,398	3,290	3,428	-5%	-3%	-4%
Operating Costs	(1,558)	(1,559)	(1,535)	(1,535)	(1,528)	(1,524)	-2%	0%	0%
PPOP	1,903	2,097	1,930	1,863	1,762	1,903	-7%	-5%	-7%
Impairment Charge	(235)	(297)	(288)	(1,368)	(120)	(275)	-49%	-91%	-56%
Other Income	40	22	(3)	25	35	29	-13%	40%	22%
Pre-Tax	1,708	1,822	1,639	520	1,677	1,657	-2%	223%	1%
Core profit	1,523	1,490	1,338	443	1,410	1,386	-7%	218%	2%
DPS (\$)	1.17	-	1.10	-	0.71	0.73	-39%	NM	-3%
Gross Loans	337,831	341,154	342,900	351,084	352,180	355,711	4%	0%	-1%
Deposits	403,978	401,250	405,076	419,660	425,938	427,862	5%	1%	0%
NPL	5,164	5,458	5,341	5,617	5,379	5,840	4%	-4%	-8%
NPA	5,210	5,361	5,386	5,809	5,440	6,031	4%	-6%	-10%
Total Allowances	4,764	4,829	4,765	5,787	5,268	5,723	11%	-9%	-8%
							Change in bps		
NIM	2.00%	2.00%	1.91%	1.82%	1.84%	1.79%	(16)	2	5
CIR	45.0%	42.6%	44.3%	45.2%	46.4%	44.5%	143	127	197
LDR	83.6%	85.0%	84.7%	83.7%	82.7%	83.1%	(94)	(98)	(45)
CASA Ratio	54.6%	55.1%	56.5%	57.0%	58.4%	57.1%	375	137	130
Credit Costs (bps)	25	34	33	157	14	31	(12)	(143)	(18)
NPL Ratio	1.53%	1.60%	1.56%	1.60%	1.53%	1.64%	0	(7)	(11)
NPA Coverage	91%	90%	88%	100%	97%	95%	600	(300)	211
CET1 (fully phased-in)	15.4%	15.4%	15.2%	14.5%	14.9%	14.2%	(48)	42	68

Source: Company reports, J.P. Morgan estimates.

Table 2: UOB FY25 earnings review

P&L (\$mn)	FY21A	FY22A	FY23A	FY24A	FY25A	YoY
Net Interest Income	6,388	8,343	9,679	9,674	9,356	-3%
Non-Interest Income	3,401	3,232	4,253	4,620	4,454	-4%
Fee Income	2,412	2,143	2,235	2,395	2,570	7%
Other Non-II	989	1,089	2,018	2,225	1,884	-15%
Operating Revenue	9,789	11,575	13,932	14,294	13,810	-3%
Operating Costs	(4,313)	(5,016)	(5,777)	(6,310)	(6,157)	-2%
PPOP	5,476	6,559	8,155	7,984	7,652	-4%
Impairment Charge	(657)	(606)	(945)	(954)	(2,073)	117%
Other Income	118	97	93	121	79	-35%
Pre-Tax	4,937	6,050	7,303	7,151	5,658	-21%
Net profit	4,075	4,573	5,711	6,045	4,681	-23%
DPS (\$)	1.20	1.35	1.70	2.05	1.81	-12%
Gross Loans	310,800	319,663	321,150	337,831	352,180	4%
Deposits	352,633	368,553	385,469	403,978	425,938	5%
NPL	5,030	5,060	4,870	5,164	5,379	4%
NPA	5,077	5,127	4,946	5,210	5,440	4%
Total Allowances	4,876	5,002	4,976	4,764	5,268	11%
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NIM	1.56%	1.86%	2.09%	2.03%	1.89%	(14)
CIR	44.1%	43.3%	41.5%	42.5%	44.6%	209
LDR	88.1%	86.7%	83.3%	83.6%	82.7%	(94)
CASA Ratio	56.2%	47.5%	48.9%	54.6%	58.4%	375
Credit Costs (bps)	21	20	24	26	63	36
NPL Ratio	1.62%	1.58%	1.52%	1.53%	1.53%	(0)
NPA Coverage	96%	98%	101%	91%	97%	540
CET1 (fully phased-in)	13.5%	13.3%	13.4%	15.4%	14.9%	(48)

Source: Company reports.

Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

United Overseas Bank (UOB) *(Underweight; Price Target: S\$34.00)*

Investment Thesis

We are UW on UOB.

- UOB has delivered RoE with the least volatility among Singapore banks over the past 20 years. This may change over the next few quarters, as asset quality risks could remain elevated.
- The bank has lagged peers on WM (limited organic and inorganic build in last 15Y), as well on USD-denominated payment/deposits (26% at UOB vs. 38%/34% at DBS/OCBC). These factors, amongst others, likely led the bank to take too much risk in areas linked to property in Asia and the US over the last decade in a bid to generate better returns. Accordingly, we are now witnessing an increase in credit risks. The timing of gross NPL formation, recoveries and upgrades, as well as evolution of collateral values should lead to volatility on credit costs and expectations thereof.
- The bank has committed to a 50% payout ratio for regular dividends. Hence, as EPS risk increases, DPS will be at risk as well. This could limit the upside for the stock.
- UOB is close to 5Y highs on fwd PB/PE, ~1.5-2SD above mean. Yet, we expect ROE to be closer to 11% in 1H26 vs. 12-13% in 4Q24/1Q25. We expect the stock to offer a more balanced risk-return trade-off closer to the mean of 1-1.1 fwd P/B; which would price in a degree of lingering AQ risks.
- Following increased spend in last 2Y, the bank is better positioned to focus on efficiency, which could pose an upside risk.

Valuation

Our Dec-26 PT of S\$34 is based on a fair P/B of 1.08x with a normalized RoE of 11.5%, a risk-free rate of 4.15%, a cost of capital of 11% and a growth rate of 4.1%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Upside risks include better-than-expected delivery on AQ, with sustained normalization of NPA formation and credit costs. On PPoP, the bank's ability to manage wins from its digital investments could lead to positive revisions, and investments coming to fruition earlier than anticipated would pose upside risks to costs.

Downside catalysts include credit cost increases, growth and NIM disappointments, and lower-than-expected dividends and buybacks. Higher operating costs would also be a downside risk. Higher-than-anticipated digital investment spending could be a drag on profitability.

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United Overseas Bank (UOB) (UOBH.SI, UOB SP) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (\$)	Price Target (\$)
30-Mar-23	N	29.95	28.5
05-Oct-23	N	28.07	28
09-Dec-23	N	27.58	27
13-Mar-24	N	28.28	30
03-Jul-24	N	31.65	32.5
06-Oct-24	N	31.86	34
10-Nov-24	OW	35.69	41
14-Jan-25	OW	36.80	43
23-Mar-25	N	37.95	40
21-May-25	N	35.40	37
13-Jul-25	N	36.86	38
08-Aug-25	N	35.81	36.5
10-Sep-25	UW	35.57	32.5
28-Nov-25	N	33.89	34
25-Jan-26	UW	39.50	34

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Sep 24, 2002. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

DBS Group Holdings (DBSM.SI, DBS SP) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (\$)	Price Target (\$)
09-Mar-23	N	30.64	31
30-Mar-23	UW	30.54	27
05-Oct-23	UW	30.20	28
09-Dec-23	UW	28.73	27.5
13-Mar-24	N	30.46	30
03-Jul-24	OW	37.10	41
06-Oct-24	OW	38.04	42
10-Nov-24	OW	42.40	50
11-Feb-25	OW	45.38	51
23-Mar-25	OW	45.31	49
21-May-25	N	44.38	47
13-Jul-25	N	45.99	48
08-Aug-25	N	49.75	50.5
10-Sep-25	OW	50.88	56
28-Nov-25	OW	54.00	70

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Dec 11, 2001. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Singapore Exchange (SGXL.SI, SGX SP) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (\$)	Price Target (\$)
29-Nov-23	N	9.39	10
20-May-24	OW	9.24	10.5
22-Aug-24	N	10.60	10.5
12-Sep-24	UW	11.76	10.5
06-Oct-24	UW	11.68	11
28-Jan-25	UW	12.23	11.1
13-Feb-25	UW	13.66	11
09-Apr-25	N	12.02	11
27-Apr-25	UW	14.36	12.8
16-Jul-25	UW	15.67	14
10-Sep-25	N	16.35	16
28-Nov-25	OW	16.60	18.5
03-Feb-26	OW	17.56	19

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
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